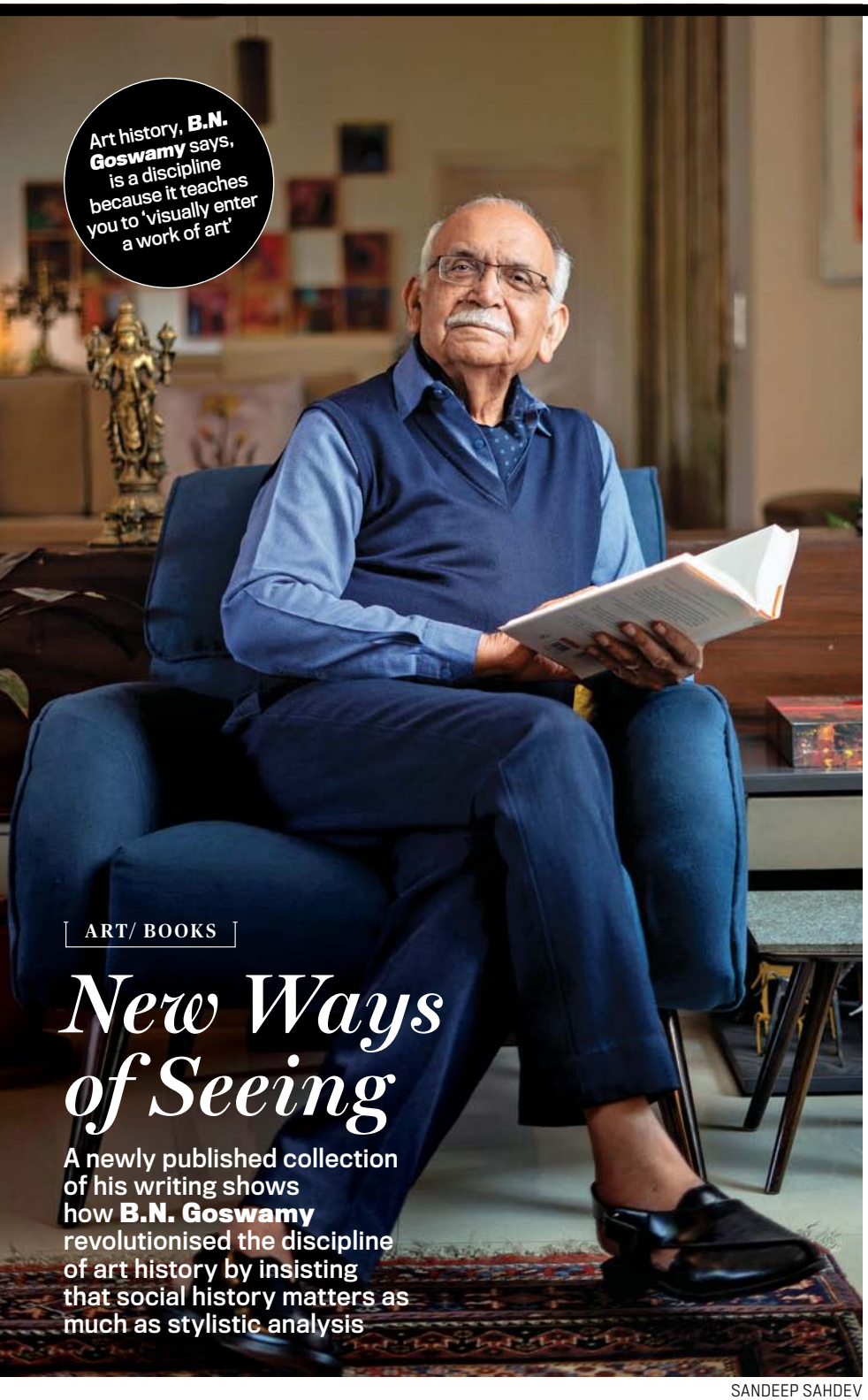
ART/ BOOKS: A GOOD ELEPHANT
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Q&A WITH MALAVIKA SARUKKAI
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Art history, **B.N. Goswamy** says, is a discipline because it teaches you to 'visually enter a work of art'

ART/ BOOKS

New Ways of Seeing

A newly published collection of his writing shows how **B.N. Goswamy** revolutionised the discipline of art history by insisting that social history matters as much as stylistic analysis

SANDEEP SAHDEV

B.N. GOSWAMY'S REGULAR column in Chandigarh's newspaper *The Tribune* is titled 'Art and Soul'. His selection of 125 short pieces written over 25 years, now published as a book, is titled *Conversations*. "Between whom?" he invites us to ask, before gamely admitting he doesn't know. Well, they read like conversations between him and us, so easy-going is his style, anticipating our questions. They are chats about art, and about old friends.

We will come to the friends presently, but we might first query the publisher's subtitle: 'India's Leading Art Historian Engages with 101 Themes & More'. Sparing his blushes over 'leading', I ask, being named as an art historian, does he consider it to be a genuine discipline? Given that he founded the Department of Art History at Panjab University in 1970, and taught there for three decades, besides writing copiously on art, we cannot be surprised that he insists it is. Not very widely practised in India but a discipline nonetheless.

On the other hand, "I have never been to a single class in art history in my life," he admits. If